

LT Credit: Surrounding Density and Diverse Uses

This credit applies to

- ▶ BD+C: New Construction (1-5 points)
- ▶ BD+C: Core and Shell (1-6 points)
- ▶ BD+C: Schools (1-5 points)
- ▶ BD+C: Data Centers (1-5 points)
- ▶ BD+C: Warehouses and Distribution Centers (1-5 points)
- ▶ BD+C: Hospitality (1-5 points)
- ▶ BD+C: Retail (1-5 points)
- ▶ BD+C: Healthcare (1 point)

INTENT

To conserve land and protect farmland and wildlife habitat by encouraging development in areas with existing infrastructure. To support neighborhood and local economies, promote walkability and low or no carbon transportation, and reduce vehicle distance traveled for all. To improve public health by encouraging daily physical activity.

REQUIREMENTS

NC, CS, RETAIL, HOSPITALITY

Option 1. Surrounding Density (2–3 points BD&C except Core and Shell, 2–4 points Core and Shell)

Locate on a site whose surrounding existing density within a ¼-mile (400-meter) offset of the project boundary meets the values in Table 1. Use either the “separate residential and nonresidential densities” or the “combined density” values.

Table 1a. Points for average density within 1/4 mile of project (IP units)

Combined density	Separate residential and nonresidential densities		Points BD&C (except Core and Shell)	Points BD&C (Core and Shell)
Square feet per acre of buildable land	Residential density (DU/acre)	Nonresidential density (FAR)		
22,000	7	0.5	2	2
35,000	12	0.8	3	4

Table 1b. Points for average density within 400 meters of project (SI units)

Combined density	Separate residential and nonresidential densities		Points BD&C (except Core and Shell)	Points BD&C (Core and Shell)
Square meters per hectare of buildable land	Residential density (DU/hectare)	Nonresidential density (FAR)		
5,050	17.5	0.5	2	2

8,035	30	0.8	3	4
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DU = dwelling unit; FAR = floor-area ratio.

SCHOOLS

Option 1. Surrounding Density and Connectivity (2-3 points)

Path 1. Surrounding Density

Locate on a site whose surrounding existing density within a ¼-mile (400-meter) offset of the project boundary meets the values in Table 1. Use either the “separate residential and nonresidential densities” or the “combined density” values.

Table 1a. Points for average density within 1/4 mile of project (IP units)

Combined density	Separate residential and nonresidential densities		Points
Square feet per acre of buildable land	Residential density (DU/acre)	Nonresidential density (FAR)	
22,000	7	0.5	2
35,000	12	0.8	3

Table 1b. Points for average density within 400 meters of project (SI units)

Combined density	Separate residential and nonresidential densities		Points
Square meters per hectare of buildable land	Residential density (DU/hectare)	Nonresidential density (FAR)	
5,050	17.5	0.5	2
8,035	30	0.8	3

DU = dwelling unit; FAR = floor-area ratio.

Physical education spaces that are part of the project site, such as playing fields and associated buildings used during sporting events only (e.g., concession stands) and playgrounds with play equipment, are excluded from the development density calculations.

Path 2. Connected Site (1-2 points)

Locate the project on a previously developed site that also meets one of the connected site conditions listed below.

Table 2. Points for connected site

Type of site	Points
Adjacent	1
Infill	2

- ▶ To qualify as an adjacent site, at least 25% of the project boundary must border parcels that are previously developed sites.
- ▶ To qualify as an infill site, at least 75% of the project boundary must border parcels that are previously developed sites.
- ▶ Bordering rights-of-way do not constitute previously developed land; it is the status of the property on the other side of the right-of-way that contributes to the calculation. Any part of the boundary that borders a water body is excluded from the calculation.

AND/OR

Option 2. Diverse Uses (1-2 points)

Construct or renovate a building or a space within a building such that the building's main entrance is within a ½-mile (800-meter) walking distance from the following number of uses (see Appendix 1), as listed below.

Table 1. Points for proximity to uses

Uses	Points
4-7	1
≥ 8	2

The following restrictions apply.

- ▶ A use counts as only one type (e.g., a retail store may be counted only once even if it sells products in several categories).
- ▶ No more than two uses in each use type may be counted (e.g. if five restaurants are within walking distance, only two may be counted).
- ▶ The counted uses must represent at least three of the five categories, exclusive of the building's primary use.

DATA CENTERS, WAREHOUSES & DISTRIBUTION CENTERS

Option 1. Development and Adjacency (2-3 points)

Construct or renovate the project on a previously developed site that was used for industrial or commercial purposes. (2 points).

OR

Construct or renovate the project on a site that is both a previously developed and an adjacent site. The adjacent sites must be currently used for industrial or commercial purposes (3 points).

AND/OR

Option 2. Transportation Resources (1-2 points)

Construct or renovate the project on a site that has two or three (1 point) or four (2 points) of the following transportation resources:

- ▶ The site is within a 10-mile (16 kilometer) driving distance of a main logistics hub, defined as an airport, seaport, *intermodal facility*, or *freight village* with intermodal transportation.
- ▶ The site is within a 1-mile (1600-meter) driving distance of an on-off ramp to a *highway*.
- ▶ The site is within a 1-mile (1600-meter) driving distance of an access point to an active freight rail line.
- ▶ The site is served by an active freight rail spur.

In all cases, a planned transportation resource must be sited, funded, and under construction by the date of the certificate of occupancy and complete within 24 months of that date.

HEALTHCARE

Option 1. Surrounding Density (1 point)

Locate on a site whose surrounding existing density within a ¼-mile (400-meter) offset of the project boundary is:

1. At least 7 dwelling units per acre (17.5 DU per hectare) with a 0.5 floor-area ratio. The counted density must be *existing* density, not zoned density, or
2. At least 22,000 square feet per acre (5 050 square meters per hectare) of buildable land.

For previously developed existing rural healthcare campus sites, achieve a minimum development density of 30,000 square feet per acre (6890 square meters per hectare).

OR

Option 2. Diverse Uses (1 point)

Construct or renovate a building on a site such that the building's main entrance is within a ½-mile (800-meter) walking distance of the main entrance of at least seven operational and publicly accessible uses (listed in Appendix 1).

The following restrictions apply.

- ▶ A use may be counted as only one type (e.g., a retail store may be counted only once even if it sells products in several categories).
- ▶ No more than two uses in each use type may be counted (e.g., if five restaurants are within walking distance, only two may be counted).
- ▶ The counted uses must represent at least three of the five categories, exclusive of the building's primary use.

ALL PROJECTS

Option 3. Walkable Location

Locate on a site with a Walk Score® or equivalent third-party walkability assessment for the following thresholds, as listed below.

Table 1. Points for walkable location (1-5 points BD+C except Core & Shell and Healthcare, 6 points Core & Shell, 1 point Healthcare)

Walk Score®	Points	Points (Core & Shell)	Points (Healthcare)
90 to 100	5	6	-
80 to 89	4	4	-
70 to 79	3	3	-
60 to 69	2	2	-
50 to 59	1	1	-
≥ 50	-	-	1

Projects attempting Option 3 are not eligible to earn points under Option 1 or Option 2.

GUIDANCE

Refer to the LEED v4 reference guide, with the following additions and modifications:

Behind the Intent

Beta Update

In this credit, data centers have been combined with warehouses and distribution centers to have different requirements, reflecting the needs of buildings devoted to housing goods (and not people). Updates also clarify that surrounding existing density is measured within a ¼-mile (400-meter) offset, not radius, of the project boundary.

A new path for school projects has been added to Option 1 to recognize the unique circumstances some schools project face during site selection, especially for communities outside of dense urban areas. Path 2, Connected Site recognizes the benefit of locating new schools near existing development.

A new option has been added for all projects to recognize the benefit of walkable locations as assessed by Walk Score® and equivalent walkability assessment tools. Walk Score® measures surrounding density, road network metrics, and destinations within walking distance and is a reasonable proxy for the metrics in Option 1 and Option 2.

Step-by-Step Guidance

Follow steps in the LEED v4 reference guide, with the following modifications:

- ▶ Data Centers have been added to the Warehouses and Distribution Centers pathway. Any reference to this pathway should be considered requirements for data centers as well.
- ▶ For Schools projects attempting Option 1, Path 2, follow guidance below for determining adjacent and infill site status.

Step 1. Identify qualifying previously developed parcels around the project site

On a vicinity map, identify parcels adjacent to the project's perimeter. For each parcel, calculate the percentage of previous development area.

- Qualifying parcels have at least 75% previous development coverage. If a portion of a lot smaller than 1 acre is previously developed, the entire lot's area may be considered previously developed.
- Start with parcels that look most developed and skip those that appear marginal.

Step 2. Confirm that the project is an adjacent site or infill site

Measure the project's entire perimeter, the length of perimeter segments adjacent to waterfront (if any), and the longest continuous perimeter segments adjacent to qualifying parcels. Use Equation 1 to determine the percentage of the project boundary adjacent to previously developed parcels.

Equation 1. Percentage of boundary adjacent to previous development

% adjacent boundary = continuous perimeter adjacent to previously developed parcels / (total perimeter - any waterfront perimeter) x 100

- To qualify as an infill site, at least 75% of the site boundary must be adjacent to qualifying previously developed parcels.
 - To qualify as an adjacent site, at least one continuous segment of the site boundary adjacent to qualifying previously developed parcels must be 25% or more of the net perimeter length.
 - If no continuous segments are at least 25% of the net perimeter length, the site does not qualify as an adjacent site.
- For projects attempting Option 3, access the project's Walk Score by entering the project address at <https://www.walkscore.com/>.

Further Explanation

Walk Score measures the walkability of an address on the following scale:

Walk Score®	Description
90-100	Walker's Paradise Daily errands do not require a car.
70-89	Very Walkable Most errands can be accomplished on foot.
50-69	Somewhat Walkable Some errands can be accomplished on foot.
25-49	Car-Dependent Most errands require a car.
0-24	Car-Dependent Almost all errands require a car.

Source: Walk Score

While quantitative walkability assessment tools, including Walk Score, provide valuable insight into the relative potential for walking in a measured location, these tools have acknowledged limitations for reflecting the actual conditions on the ground and the safety and efficacy of walking. Project teams are encouraged to utilize other resources, including but not limited to multimodal transportation data collection and analysis, travel surveys, and pedestrian safety audits. For more information, refer to <https://www.walkscore.com/methodology.shtml>

In addition, a project's design has the potential to influence walking and other active modes as alternatives to driving through the orientation of the building on the site and connectivity between the site and the surrounding street network, and by including high-quality sidewalks and crossing facilities that enhance multimodal travel on and around the project.

Required Documentation

- Data centers have been added to the Warehouses and Distribution Centers pathway. Any reference in the tables to the pathway should be considered requirements for Data Centers as well.
- For Schools projects attempting Option 1, Path 2, a map of surrounding land and its status (previously developed, per the definition in Step-by-Step Guidance) is required documentation.
- For projects attempting Option 3, attach a screenshot of the resulting Walk Score, making sure to include the project's address and score.

Connection to Ongoing Performance

- LEED O+M LT prerequisite Transportation Performance: Locating a building in a dense area served by transit and diverse uses would have a significant positive impact on the transportation patterns of building occupants. As a result, this credit makes the performance-based LT prerequisite Transportation Performance more achievable.